

Manohar Lohia, Nath Pai and E.M.S. Namboodiripad and others who provided alternative ideas to the ruling establishment even as they opposed it in Parliament. They were men inspired and inspiring.

Sixty-two years after Independence, a third generation of leaders is now in control. Even a cursory glance at the parliamentary roster will convince you that there is no place in the world which is as fertile for political dynasties as India. Nearly a third of the members of the 15th Lok Sabha are relatives of leaders of various parties. And their numbers will no doubt keep growing. It's the triumph of genealogy over ideology. In Britain, a small-town grocer's daughter could go on to become among the longest serving prime ministers, and in the United States a failed Hollywood actor worked his way up the political ladder to first become a state governor, and later, among the country's most popular presidents. But in India, leadership is not earned; it is inherited or grabbed. Until the mid-1970s, the Congress and the then Jan Sangh competed with each other in membership enrolment drives. Today, leaders sit in their plush offices and decide who should be chosen. Time was when the regions threw up leaders who caught the imagination of the masses enough to challenge the power centres in Delhi. Not many of today's breed of politicians—the inheritor class particularly—will remember that a young turk called Chandra Shekhar from the boondocks of Ballia in eastern Uttar Pradesh contested the elections to the Congress Working Committee as a rebel against the official candidate put up by Indira Gandhi. And won. Or that a frail Jayaprakash Narayan could rouse the

conscience of the country and bring a tyrannical leader to her knees. The “people's parties”, as they like to call themselves, have lost ground and their moral fibre too. Sonia Gandhi is the Congress president, selected not elected. The BJP boasts of its democratic credentials, but lets a small cabal run the party. The Communists vow to fight communalism and corruption with equal fervour but are blatant in allying with a rabid fundamentalist and punishing a chief minister who showed the courage to take on the corrupt. Regional parties that came into prominence by playing on sectarian instincts are themselves falling victims to the claims and counter claims of sub-sects within. There is no leader with a pan-Indian appeal and the once regional satraps are unable now to carry even their own states. We have national leaders without a state base and state leaders without a space at the Centre. Meanwhile, the other India, denied a share in the power at the Centre, has thrown up its own leadership based on caste and community.

Winston Churchill was proved wrong in predicting the disintegration of India following Independence and Lord Linlithgow, the viceroy who left India in 1945, couldn't have been more off the mark when he said it would take Indians half a century to come to grips with parliamentary democracy. Despite deep divisions of religion, caste and language, we are still one. And as the 1977 elections which gave the country its first non-Congress government showed, parliamentary democracy is in safe hands, not of the elected leaders, but in the hands of the people who elect them. But there is something happening that, far from strengthening democracy, may do it incalculable harm. It is the consolida-

● According to a statistical analysis, a majority of the Lok Sabha members speak at speeds ranging between 120 and 150 words per minute. Some can go up to 180 words per minute and a few reach the speed of 180 to 200 words per minute.

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